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A digital camera can be a versatile device—it can capture movie clips at up to 30 frames per second; comes with advanced imaging technology, not to mention cutting-edge inbuilt software; you can burn captured video on a DVD; or watch images you have shot on a TV. And you don't even need a PC for all this. Some digital cameras even provide an inbuilt slide-show feature.

The PictBridge standard is another good thing that has happened to digicams (See "Keep the PC Out of the Picture", on printing photos directly from PictBridge-enabled cameras. Page 57 of this issue of Digit). It allows a direct connection between a digital camera and a printer for printing images. With the PC out of the picture, it speeds up the printing process, and takes away image resizing and paper quality hassles. You only need to plug in the camera to the printer and press a few buttons.

The price of a point-and-shoot digital camera that offers decent image quality is still on the higher side. But it is worth it when you consider how much creative fun you can have. Of course, one must not forget the *click at will* freedom that a digital camera offers—point, shoot, delete what you don't like, and store the rest as precious memories, or works of art.

Loading Up

We rounded up 29 cameras from 12 brands. We chose a price range of Rs 10,000 to Rs 30,000—it had something for everyone. We decided upon Rs 10,000 as the entry level since most cameras below this price don't offer satisfactory results.

The Rs 30,000 barrier was decided upon because anything beyond this price is also beyond the budget of the average Indian. Of course, if you want something that is high-end, you are better off importing it at a lower price.

Orite, Premiere and D'zign were the new entrants amongst the lesser known brands. HP was the new heavyweight that joined

Canon, Kodak and Sony in the Big Boys' camp. Fuji did not participate in the shootout.

LESS THAN Rs 20,000 Price crash!

Cameras in the price range of Rs 12,000 to Rs 15,000 a year ago are now available for Rs 7,000 to Rs 8,000. It is now possible to buy a 3-megapixel camera with a 3X optical zoom, and a degree of manual override, such as white balance and flash-mode setting for Rs 20,000 or less. Our sub-Rs 20,000 category started from Rs 8,500. Eleven models made it to this category—three from Kodak and Orite, two each from Canon, Nikon, Olympus and Samsung, and one each from Casio, Creative, D'zign, Premier and Sony.

What They Offered

A new entrant, the Orite VC-5000Z, made a mark. A 5.3 megapixel camera, this Orite model is capable of a 2,560 x 1,920 image resolution. The only other camera to hit the 5 megapixel mark in this category was the VC-R500—again from Orite.

Most other cameras were 3.2 megapixel ones, even if there were a few exceptions such as the Kodak CX7220 and the Premiere DC2302 with an obsolete 2 megapixel CCD. The Sony was 4.1 megapixels; so were the Kodak CX7430 and the Nikon Coolpix 4100.

In terms of compactness, nothing came close to the eminently portable Casio Exilim Ex-Z30. The Ex-Z30 is just 2.3 cm thick, and weighs about 125 gm. This, coupled with its LCD screen, makes it a great outdoor companion.

Optical zoom gives you freedom to capture distant images without compromising on quality. Most cameras in this range had 3X optical zoom, with only the Kodak CX7220 having 2.1X. However, four models, the Canon A310, the D'zign, the Olympus C-160 and the Samsung 301, don't have this feature at all. They had digital zoom, which was as high as 5.1X in the Canon A310. A digital zoom is not the same as an optical one, in terms of quality of image obtainable while using it.

White balance is a vital feature for a digital camera. One